

Being prepared

Most girls have their first period, known as menarche, around the age of 12, although it's not uncommon to start earlier or later. Feeling apprehensive is natural, but talking to a trusted adult can help a teen feel more prepared. Once a teen starts noticing vaginal discharge (white or yellow fluid) in her underwear, it's useful to have sanitary protection and spare underwear on hand, as the first period is likely to happen soon.

GOOD TO KNOW

What to expect

- Your period normally starts about two years after your breasts start developing and about a year after pubic hair starts to grow.
- There probably won't be a sudden gush of blood. In fact, many girls don't notice at first. There might be a feeling of dampness or a few spots of blood in your underwear.
- A period usually lasts three to seven days. The amount of blood lost during a period is very small, typically between 3 and 5 tablespoons, though it may seem like more.
- Menstrual blood can be bright red, dark red, or brown, and is made up of the discarded lining of the uterus.
- Nobody else knows if you have your period, unless you tell them.

Ups and downs

Feeling tired or emotional in the days leading up to a period is completely normal. Some people also experience bloating, breast tenderness, backaches, or cramping and abdominal pain. These symptoms are referred to as premenstrual syndrome (PMS) and are caused by changing hormone levels.

PMS can start up to ten days to two weeks before a period, but everyone is different. Taking painkillers, relaxing with a hot-water bottle, or doing some exercise can soothe physical discomfort.

► Feel-good chemicals

Exercise releases endorphins, natural painkillers that elevate a person's mood.



GOOD TO KNOW

Premenstrual syndrome (PMS)

There are ways to make PMS feel more manageable.

- Let people know how you are feeling.
- Eat healthy and get a good night's sleep.
- Stay active and exercise.
- Recognize how PMS affects your mood.
- See a doctor if PMS symptoms are very severe.

Irregular periods

In the first couple of years, the amount of blood lost each period can vary. It is also common for periods to happen irregularly, but over time the menstrual cycle should settle into a pattern.

It's important to see a doctor if periods were once regular but then stop, if they are exceptionally painful, or if the amount of bleeding increases. If a teen has had sex and misses a period, it may be a sign that she is pregnant.



△ Keeping track

Making a note on a phone or calendar can help with predicting when the next period might be due.

Living life

Although they can sometimes be uncomfortable, periods shouldn't restrict someone's lifestyle. With sanitary protection, everyone should feel confident and able to do the activities they love.

